

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN NIGER

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

The harm in Niger is of a particular and dangerous kind, because for fully half a century the desert around two remote northern towns has been mined for uranium, leaving behind not only poverty but radioactivity: contaminated water, poisoned soil, and mountains of radioactive waste left open to the wind. Niger is one of the world's great sources of uranium, the ore that fuels nuclear power, and near the twin mining towns of **Arlit and Akokan**, on the southern edge of the Sahara, French-operated mines drew that uranium from the earth for the better part of fifty years to feed the reactors of France and the rest of Europe. What they have left behind is documented and grave: drinking water with uranium above internationally safe limits, streets with radiation many times the normal background level, radioactive scrap metal sold in local markets and built into people's homes, and, by independent accounts, tens of millions of tonnes of radioactive waste lying exposed, drying and blowing across the open land. One of the two great mines has now closed for good, leaving a contested and unfinished clean-up; the other, and the wealth still buried beneath the desert, have become the subject of a bitter dispute since a recent change of government moved to take control of them. The region is poor and dangerous. But the levers here are real, because the harm can be measured beyond any denial.

In a poor, insecure region, those who would confront Niger's uranium contamination work carefully, through independent science and international accountability — and the tools are real. The distinctive lever is the **independent radiation science**: the contamination — the poisoned water, the irradiated streets, the exposed waste — can be measured by independent scientists, so the harm cannot be denied, an unshakeable foundation. Niger's uranium **fuels the "clean" nuclear power of France and Europe**, so the reactors and their clean-energy claim carry responsibility back to the source — a powerful reputational lever. The company that mined it is a **French state enterprise**, answerable in principle to French law and to its own name. The **clean-up and remediation** the closed mine and the poisoned water demand are a concrete obligation, owed and unfinished. And the **international nuclear, health, and human-rights bodies** reach a harm of this gravity. But these tools have grave limits, and this guide states them plainly. Uranium is central to Niger's economy, and the mines are now largely in the state's hands after a bitter dispute and a recent change of government — a political matter that must be handled with strict neutrality, the work kept to the environmental and health harm. The region is poor, remote, and dangerous, in an insecure Sahel that has known rebellion and grave security threats, so the work must be careful and everyone protected absolutely. So the work must favour the independent-science, fuel-chain, home-country, and international channels over any confrontation, protecting individuals absolutely and shielding identities. And the honest prize is the contamination measured and exposed, the clean-up demanded, the fuel chain and the company held to account — carefully, through science and international accountability, not an open stop. These tools all bear on the uranium legacy that defines the country; a community facing any other project draws on the same careful, largely external toolkit — environmental scrutiny where it functions, the international frameworks, and independent documentation. Above all, protect the people.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You cannot mount open confrontation in a poor, dangerous region, and you must never endanger anyone. What can be done is to build on a harm that cannot be denied: measure the radioactive contamination

through independent science; carry the case back up the nuclear fuel chain to the "clean" power it feeds and to the French state enterprise that mined it; demand the clean-up owed; and engage the international nuclear, health, and human-rights bodies — all through science and international accountability, neutral on the political dispute, and protecting everyone absolutely.

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Niger is among the hardest and most dangerous settings in this guide, and honesty about that is the first and gravest discipline. Uranium is central to the economy; the mines are now largely in the state's hands after a bitter, political dispute that demands neutrality; the region is poor, remote, and dangerous; and there is no landmark victory. This is not a fight for open confrontation. It is careful work through independent science and international accountability, whose realistic prize is the contamination measured and exposed, the clean-up demanded, and the fuel chain and company held to account — while everyone is protected absolutely and the politics left strictly aside.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Who Actually Decides

Power over the uranium is now contested between the state and the departed operators, but the decisions a careful effort can reach run through science and accountability: the **independent scientists** who measure the radiation; the **French state enterprise and its home country**, answerable to French law and reputation for the legacy it left; the **nuclear fuel chain** — the reactors and utilities the uranium fed; and the **international nuclear, health, and human-rights bodies**. Keep clear of the political dispute and the insecurity, and map who can be reached safely before spending a week on it.

How the Harm Moves — and Where You Jump In

The harm is a legacy — the contaminated water, the irradiated ground, the exposed waste, the contested clean-up — and a fuel chain that carried the uranium to Europe's reactors. You enter through the independent science that measures the contamination beyond denial; through the fuel chain and the reputational responsibility it carries to the "clean" power; through the French state enterprise's home-country accountability; and through the clean-up obligation. Enter through science and international accountability, carefully, and neutral on the politics.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the uranium: where it went — the reactors and utilities of France and Europe it fueled — and the responsibility that flows back. Follow the operator: the French state enterprise and its home-country and reputational obligations. Follow the waste: the exposed radioactive material, the poisoned water, the contested clean-up owed. Follow the science: the independent measurements no denial can erase. The leverage lies in the independent science, the fuel chain, the home-country accountability, and the clean-up demand.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Domestic oversight is weak, contested, and dangerous, but the independent scientists, the French state enterprise's home-country regulators and public, the nuclear industry that consumed the uranium, and the international nuclear, health, and human-rights bodies are the watchers a careful case engages. The harm's measurability makes it hard for any of them to look away.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

No Nigerian effort openly halts or reverses this harm easily, and honesty requires saying so — the region is poor and dangerous and the politics contested. What the careful tools can deliver is the contamination measured and exposed, the clean-up demanded, and the fuel chain and company held to account. The single most decisive move is **the independent radiation science, carried up the nuclear fuel chain to the company and its home country**, because a harm measured beyond denial cannot be waved away, and because the "clean" power and the French state enterprise are uniquely exposed to it. The independent science is the distinctive, unshakeable lever; the fuel chain the reputational reach; the home-country accountability the company's exposure; the clean-up demand the concrete obligation. The realistic prize is real, pursued carefully and safely.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions. **What is the harm?** — the poisoned water, the irradiated ground, the radioactive scrap, the exposed waste, the contested clean-up. **What measures it?** — the independent radiation science that cannot be denied. **Where does the fuel chain lead?** — the reactors and "clean" power the uranium fed. **Who is accountable?** — the French state enterprise and its home country. **How is everyone kept safe?** — the overriding question, answered by science, international channels, and shielded identities. Pick the harm where the independent science and the fuel-chain or home-country accountability give the clearest, safest handle.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Build the case in layers, carefully. **Layer one: the measured harm** — the uranium in the water, the radiation in the streets, the scrap in the homes, the exposed waste, measured by independent science beyond any denial. **Layer two: the chain and the accountability** — the fuel chain to Europe's reactors, the French state enterprise's home-country and reputational obligations, the clean-up owed. **Layer three: the channel and the safety** — which independent scientists, international bodies, or home-country regulators to reach, and the absolute discipline of protecting individuals, shielding identities, and staying neutral on the politics. A case built on measured, undeniable radiation and carried up the fuel chain is one that even the powerful cannot easily dismiss, and one that can be pursued safely.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **harm record**: the independent radiation measurements — the water, the streets, the scrap, the waste. Gather the **chain record**: where the uranium went, the reactors and utilities it fed, the "clean" power it claims. Gather the **accountability record**: the French state enterprise's identity, home-country obligations, and the clean-up owed. Gather the **channel record**: the independent scientists, the international nuclear, health, and human-rights bodies. Gather the **safety discipline**: confirm the work shields identities, uses international channels, and stays neutral on the politics.

STEP 3: BUILDING THE SCIENTIFIC AND INTERNATIONAL COALITION

The coalition here is scientific, international, and protective, because the region is dangerous. Build it from the **independent scientists** who measure the radiation; the **affected communities**, whose testimony must be gathered through trusted channels that shield identities; the **international nuclear, health, and human-rights bodies**; and the **home-country advocates and public** where the company answers. Frame everything around the measured contamination and the clean-up owed, never around the political dispute; protect individuals absolutely; mind the ethnic and political sensitivities; and never expose anyone to danger.

STEP 4: THE INDEPENDENT SCIENCE, THE FUEL CHAIN & THE CLEAN-UP — HOLDING THE HARM TO ACCOUNT

Set expectations honestly: the levers are real but constrained by poverty, danger, and contested politics, so the prize is exposure, accountability, and clean-up, not an open stop.

The Independent Radiation Science

The distinctive, unshakeable lever is the **independent radiation science**: the contamination — the poisoned water, the irradiated streets, the exposed waste — can be measured by independent scientists, so the harm cannot be denied. Ground everything in measurement beyond dispute.

The Fuel Chain and the Home Country

Niger's uranium **fuels the "clean" nuclear power of France and Europe**, so the reactors and their clean-energy claim carry responsibility back to the source, and the **French state enterprise** that mined it answers, in principle, to French law and its own name. Carry the measured harm up the fuel chain and to the company's home country.

The Clean-Up Demand and the International Bodies

The **clean-up and remediation** the closed mine and the poisoned water demand are a concrete, owed obligation, and the **international nuclear, health, and human-rights bodies** reach a harm of this gravity. Pursued together — the independent science, the fuel chain and home-country accountability, and the clean-up demand and international bodies — these levers expose the harm and press the accountability, while protecting everyone.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case, always to measured harm and accountability. **For the independent scientists**: here is contamination to measure beyond any denial. **For the nuclear fuel chain**: here is the harm behind your "clean" power. **For the French state enterprise's home country**: here is the legacy your state company left, and the clean-up owed. **For the international bodies**: here is a radioactive harm of grave concern. **For the world**: here is the human cost of the uranium that fueled Europe's reactors. **The golden rule**: ground everything in the measured, undeniable science, carry it up the fuel chain and to the home country, demand the clean-up, keep neutral on the politics, and protect everyone absolutely.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media must be handled with the greatest care in a dangerous region, and largely through international and scientific channels. Frame any attention around **the measured contamination and the clean-up owed**: the poisoned water, the irradiated ground, the exposed waste — and the "clean" power and the company behind

it — never around the political dispute. Carry it through the independent scientific findings, the international press, and the human-rights and nuclear watchdogs, never through anything that exposes anyone or touches the insecurity. A few cautions govern everything: never expose an individual; stay neutral on the politics; frame it around the measured harm; protect everyone; and let the independent radiation science carry the weight.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message careful, science-grounded, neutral on the politics, and protective of everyone.

8A — To an independent scientific body: request or present the radiation measurements of the water, ground, and waste.

8B — On the fuel chain: connect the measured harm to the "clean" nuclear power the uranium fueled.

8C — To the French state enterprise's home-country regulator or public: set out the legacy left and the clean-up owed.

8D — On the clean-up: document the contested, unfinished remediation and press for its completion.

8E — To an international nuclear, health, or human-rights body: describe the radioactive harm and request engagement.

8F — To a community source (through trusted channels): gather testimony while shielding identities.

8G — To an international watchdog: share the measured case and request scrutiny.

8H — To the international public: summarise the human cost of the uranium — grounded in the science — without exposing anyone or touching the politics.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

The first 48 hours: assemble the independent radiation measurements of the water, streets, and waste; write the one-page case tying the harm to the fuel chain and the clean-up owed. **The fastest-moving levers:** the independent science, the fuel chain, and the home-country accountability. **Emergency action:** where the contamination is acute, the independent measurements and the international health and nuclear bodies are the sharpest, safest handles. Throughout, shield identities, stay neutral on the politics, and expose no one.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

The field here is not merely tilted but poor, dangerous, and politically contested. Recognise it plainly and adjust the aim — not an open stop, but the harm measured and exposed, the clean-up demanded, the accountability pressed. Lean on the levers the tilt cannot erase: the independent radiation science no denial can touch, the fuel-chain and home-country accountability, the clean-up obligation, the international bodies. And accept the honest limits — the uranium is central to the economy, the mines contested, the region dangerous — while still exposing the harm through science and accountability, and protecting everyone.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO BENEFITS

In a poor, insecure region with contested control of great mineral wealth, the dangers include the security threats, the political dispute, and any who profit while the contamination is left. Respond only through the **careful, scientific, and international channels**: the independent radiation science, the fuel chain, the home-country accountability, the clean-up demand, the international bodies. Never through open confrontation, and never touching the political dispute or the insecurity. **On safety and care**: this note governs everything. Niger's uranium region lies in an insecure Sahel that has known rebellion and grave security threats. Favour the independent-science, fuel-chain, home-country, and international channels over any confrontation; protect individuals absolutely and shield identities; gather testimony through trusted channels; mind the ethnic and political sensitivities; and stay neutral on the politics. Protection is the governing rule.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps run in parallel, carefully and largely through international and scientific channels. The measured contamination feeds the fuel-chain case, the home-country accountability, and the clean-up demand at once; the scientific and international coalition organises safely alongside; any attention runs through the science and the watchdogs. A rough timeline: **weeks one to four**, assemble the independent measurements and the fuel-chain and accountability record; **months two to six**, carry the case to the fuel chain, the home country, and the international bodies, and press the clean-up; **beyond**, sustain the exposure and the accountability. The core discipline: science-grounded, internationally pressed, neutral on the politics, and protective of everyone.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Niger is among the hardest and most dangerous grounds in this guide, and this guide does not pretend otherwise. It does not claim the harm can be openly stopped or swiftly reversed in a poor, insecure, contested region, or that a landmark victory exists — none of that is true. What it claims is real: that the radioactive contamination — the poisoned water, the irradiated streets, the exposed waste — can be measured by independent science beyond any denial; that Niger's uranium fueled the "clean" nuclear power of France and Europe, carrying responsibility back to the source; that the French state enterprise answers, in principle, to its home country and its name; and that the clean-up owed and the international bodies reach a harm of this gravity. The levers work through science and international accountability, and the prize is the contamination measured and exposed, the clean-up demanded, the fuel chain and company held to account — not an open stop. For a poor, dangerous region poisoned by the uranium that fueled distant reactors, that careful work — grounded in undeniable science, neutral on the politics, and protecting everyone absolutely — is not a lesser ambition. It is the only responsible and effective one.